

Stirling Castle - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Stirling: The Brooch That Clasps Scotland

Stirling's strategic logic is visible from the ramparts in one glance. The castle crowns another volcanic crag-and-tail — the same geology as Edinburgh — but its significance is the ground below: until modern drainage, the carse of the upper Forth was near-impassable bog, and Stirling Bridge was the lowest practical crossing of the river. Effectively every army moving between Lowlands and Highlands funneled through this gap, which is why the castle is called the brooch that clasps Highlands and Lowlands together, why it changed hands constantly, and why the two defining battles of the Wars of Independence happened within sight of these walls. At Stirling Bridge in 1297, Wallace and Andrew Murray let the English cross the narrow timber bridge until roughly half were over, then destroyed the divided army — a militia beating feudal cavalry, which shocked Europe. At Bannockburn in 1314, the trigger was this castle itself: its besieged English garrison had agreed to surrender if not relieved by midsummer, forcing Edward the Second to march north into ground Bruce chose. The famous prelude — Bruce, on a palfrey, sidestepping Henry de Bohun's charge and killing him with one axe blow before his whole army — is attested in near-contemporary sources, along with Bruce's reported complaint about the broken axe shaft. The Wallace Monument on Abbey Craig, visible across the valley, marks where Wallace watched the English deploy; the bridge you can see today is the fifteenth-century stone successor, slightly downstream of the fatal one.

Anatomy of an Ambush: Stirling Bridge

Stand on the ramparts and you can dissect the battle of 1297 like a staff officer, because the whole thing turned on a single object, the bridge. The old timber crossing, roughly where the stone bridge stands today, was narrow enough that horsemen could only pass two abreast. That is the entire secret. A bridge meters an army out at a rate you do not control, which means a smaller force holding the far bank can defeat a much larger one, provided it has the nerve to wait.

Wallace and Andrew Moray had the nerve. They watched from the slopes of Abbey Craig, where the Wallace Monument now stands, and they let the English vanguard file across at the bridge's own patient pace. When perhaps half the army was over, they struck the bridgehead and seized it. The English were now cut cleanly in two, with a river between the halves and no way to reinforce. The portion that had crossed was pinned in a loop of the Forth on soft ground where cavalry could not maneuver, and methodically destroyed, while the rest of the army stood helpless on the south bank and watched.

Among the dead was Hugh de Cressingham, Edward the First's treasurer in Scotland, a man so loathed for his taxes that the Scots, according to the chronicles, flayed the skin from his body and cut it into strips as tokens. One strip, the story goes, Wallace kept as a sword belt. Whether or not that grisly detail is literally true, the fact that it was told, and relished, tells you how bitter the occupation had become.

The English commander, John de Warenne, Earl of Surrey, was still safely on the south bank. Seeing the disaster, he ordered the bridge destroyed and retreated, abandoning the field. And here is the injustice that history loves to forget. Andrew Moray, the co-commander and by many judgments the finer soldier

of the two, was badly wounded at Stirling Bridge and died of it within a couple of months. Because he did not survive to fight again, posterity kept only Wallace's name, and turned a shared victory into a solo legend. When you look down at the river, remember it was won by two men, and by a bridge that did more killing than any sword.

Bannockburn, and a Castle Nobody Could Keep

If Stirling Bridge was an ambush, Bannockburn in 1314 was the opposite, a set-piece experiment in whether disciplined infantry could hold chosen ground against the full combined-arms weight of a medieval superpower, cavalry and archers together, for two entire days. It could, and the ground you can see to the south is why.

Robert the Bruce prepared meticulously. He anchored one flank in the woods of the New Park, hemmed the English into the boggy carse between the Bannock burn and the Forth, and seeded the firm approaches with hidden pits and iron caltrops to break up any cavalry charge before it landed. Then he trusted his schiltrons, dense circular hedges of long spears, unbreakable to a horse that will not impale itself. What made Bannockburn revolutionary was that on the second day these schiltrons did not merely stand and receive the charge, as spear formations were expected to do. They advanced, grinding forward and compressing the enormous English army into a shrinking pocket against the streams, where its numbers became a liability, men and horses trampling each other with nowhere to go.

Edward the Second escaped the rout by galloping, and where he galloped tells you everything about this castle's importance. He fled straight here, to Stirling, and hammered for admission, and the governor, Philip de Mowbray, refused to open the gate. Mowbray had made a pact to surrender the castle if it was not relieved by midsummer, and that unrelieved pact was the very reason Edward had marched north in the first place. So the King of England, fresh from the worst defeat of his reign, was locked out of the fortress the whole war had been fought over, by his own side.

That is the deeper truth of this rock. It was so valuable that it was almost never safely held. Across the Wars of Independence the castle changed hands again and again, and time after time both sides deliberately wrecked their own defenses, slighting the walls, rather than risk the enemy capturing an intact fortress. The stone you stand on sits atop an extinct volcanic crag, scoured by glaciers into the steep-fronted, long-tailed shape that made it commanding and defensible. Precisely because it was the key to Scotland, no one could relax while holding it. The prize was also the trap.

James V's Palace: Renaissance Propaganda in Stone

Stirling's Royal Palace, built for James the Fifth in the late 1530s, is among the earliest and finest Renaissance buildings in Britain, and its recent restoration is a bold curatorial argument: rather than conserving bare stone, Historic Scotland returned the interiors to a researched best-guess of their 1540s appearance — blazing color, gilding, oak, and tapestry — on the principle that authentic-looking age is itself a fiction; these rooms were built to dazzle. The exterior facades carry one of Scotland's great sculptural programs, a parade of gods, soldiers and the king himself, advertising James as a European Renaissance prince to rival his uncle Henry the Eighth and his father-in-law Francis of France — the palace was substantially built for his French queen, Mary of Guise, with French masons. The ceiling of the King's Presence Chamber held the Stirling Heads, meter-wide carved oak medallions of kings, queens, heroes and courtiers — Scotland's other crown jewels, as they're sometimes called; original survivors are displayed upstairs, recarved versions overhead. The Hunt of the Unicorn tapestries in the Queen's chambers are hand-woven recreations of the set now in the Met Cloisters in New York — a fourteen-year project completed in 2014, partly woven on-site — justified by inventories showing James owned over a hundred tapestries including unicorn hunts. And the Great Hall's exterior limewash, King's Gold, is the restoration's most argued-about choice: garish to modern eyes, correct to the sources, and visible from the motorway — which is, of course, the sixteenth-century intention translated.

The Stirling Heads: A Ceiling of Kings

Give the Stirling Heads unhurried attention, both the carved replicas overhead in the King's Inner Hall and, better still, the surviving originals in the gallery upstairs. These are oak roundels roughly a meter across, carved around 1540 for the ceiling of James the Fifth's presence chamber, and their design is a deliberate argument. The company they portray is pointedly mixed. James himself and his queen, contemporary courtiers and jesters, alongside Roman emperors, Hercules, and classical worthies, plus a handful of figures scholars still cannot securely identify. The message to any visitor craning upward was that the Stewart court belonged in the same frame as the ancient world, that this small northern dynasty was a Renaissance power fluent in the same language of emperors and heroes as France or the papacy.

Their survival is a small miracle and a good story. In 1777 the decaying ceiling collapsed, and the heads were taken down and, crucially, not valued. They were dispersed and put to humbler use. Several ended up as garden ornaments, weathering in the open air. One, the tradition goes, was pressed into service as the lid of a butter churn. For decades they were scattered and half-forgotten, until patient antiquarian detective work reassembled most of the set, tracking down survivors one at a time. Of the original ceiling, a good majority were recovered, and it is those weathered, battered oak faces you meet upstairs.

The bright replicas overhead restore something the originals can no longer show, the color. This is the key to reading the whole palace. We instinctively picture the Renaissance in the honey tones of bare stone and stripped oak, but that is an accident of age and Victorian taste. These rooms were painted, gilded, and hung with tapestry to the point of sensory overload. The same instinct explains the exterior King's Gold limewash that so startles visitors expecting weathered grey. The recreated ochre is evidence-based and, to modern eyes, almost aggressive, which is the point. This was propaganda in pigment, commissioned by a king chronically anxious about his standing, competing directly with his uncle Henry the Eighth and his father-in-law Francis of France. The faces in the ceiling were James insisting, to everyone who looked up, that he too was Caesar.

The Great Hall, the Chapel, and the Knot Below

Step into the Great Hall, the largest medieval banqueting hall in Scotland, and look up at the roof, because it is the single most impressive act of restoration on the whole rock. The original hammerbeam roof, a soaring lattice of oak that vaults the entire space without a central support, had been lost for centuries after the army converted the hall into barracks and floored it over. What you see now is a full reconstruction, completed in the late 1990s, built with green oak and traditional carpentry to match the original engineering. Note the four great fireplaces and the fine windows at the dais end, the “cup and can” bay where the king sat, and the exterior limewash, that same King’s Gold, deliberately visible for miles. This hall was a machine for royal theater, and it worked. It was here that James the Sixth staged the fantastical 1594 baptism feast, cannon-firing model ship and all.

Nearby stands the Chapel Royal, and its history is a lesson in royal impatience. The present chapel was not medieval but was built at speed by James the Sixth in 1594, essentially as a purpose-made stage for his son Prince Henry’s christening, replacing the older chapel where his mother, Mary, had been crowned half a century earlier. A king who wants a spectacle simply builds a new church for it, in months. Look for the painted frieze inside, part of the seventeenth-century decoration, and imagine the space filled with the choral music and Protestant pageantry of a monarch determined to advertise his heir to watching ambassadors.

Then, before you leave the ramparts, look down at the formal garden below the castle, a curious stepped earthwork of grassed terraces and a raised central mound, geometric and strange. This is the King’s Knot, the surviving earthworks of a royal ornamental garden laid out in the 1620s, on ground that had held royal gardens far earlier. Local tradition, repeated since at least the sixteenth century, insists that this spot was the site of King Arthur’s Round Table, and that knights once jousting here. There is no proof, and the association is almost certainly romantic invention, but the folklore itself is old, and it tells you how deeply Stirling had woven itself into the myth of Scotland. From up here you see the whole composition at once, fortress on the crag, garden at its foot, the battlefields beyond, an entire kingdom arranged as a view.

Coronations, Childhoods and a Court of Characters

Stirling was the Stewart dynasty's nursery and safe room — royal heirs were repeatedly raised here precisely because the castle was so defensible. Mary, Queen of Scots was crowned in the old Chapel Royal in September 1543 at nine months old, reportedly crying throughout while nobles carried the regalia for her; she spent her early childhood here before being shipped to France at five, ahead of Henry the Eighth's "Rough Wooing" — his war to force her betrothal to his son. Her own son, the future James the Sixth and First, was in turn baptized and raised at Stirling; his 1566 baptism festivities included Scotland's first recorded fireworks display, and the present Chapel Royal was rebuilt at speed for the 1594 baptism of his heir, Prince Henry — for whose celebratory banquet the fish course entered the Great Hall aboard a full-rigged model ship, cannons firing. The court that swirled through these rooms supplied Scotland's best anecdotes: John Damian, the Italian alchemist-courtier who in 1507 leapt from the walls with feathered wings bound for France, landed in the midden with a broken thigh, and blamed his choice of hen feathers — the poet William Dunbar mocked him in verse that survives. After the crowns united in 1603 and the court left for London, Stirling's decline into a barracks ironically preserved it: the army subdivided but never demolished, and two centuries of military whitewash protected the very interiors now restored. The Great Kitchens' recreated banquet tableau is genuinely good — and the castle's resident cat, if on duty, outranks everyone.

John Damian: Alchemy, Feathers and a Poet's Revenge

The birdman of Stirling deserves more than the punchline, because the flight was only the most spectacular failure in a career of expensive failures, all bankrolled by a fascinated king. John Damian was an Italian who arrived at the court of James the Fourth as a physician and, more importantly, as an alchemist. James, one of the most intellectually curious monarchs of the age, set him up with furnaces both here at Stirling and at Holyrood, and paid handsomely for years while Damian pursued the quinta essentia, the fabled fifth element, the distilled quintessence that was supposed to transmute base metal into gold and confer near-miraculous powers. The royal accounts record the money pouring in, for quicksilver and coals and aqua vitae, and no gold ever pouring out. As a reward, and perhaps to fund the habit, the king made Damian Abbot of Tongland, a wealthy monastery whose income he could enjoy without, by all accounts, troubling himself much about the monks.

Then, in 1507, came the leap. Damian announced he would fly from the castle walls to France, faster than the king's ambassadors could travel by sea, fitted himself with feathered wings, and launched from the ramparts before the assembled court. He fell almost straight down into the midden, the castle dung heap, and broke his thigh. His explanation is the finest excuse in Scottish history. The failure, he said, lay in the feathers. Some hens' feathers had been mixed in with the eagle plumage, and being the feathers of a bird that loves the dunghill and cannot rise, they had naturally sought the ground and dragged him down. Had the wings been pure eagle, he would have soared.

The court poet William Dunbar found all this irresistible and immortalized Damian in savage comic verse, casting him as the false friar of Tongland who tried to fly to Turkey and was set upon in mid-air by an outraged mob of birds of every species, magpies and rooks and hawks, who mobbed and pecked him until he tumbled from the sky into the mire. Dunbar's satire survives, which is precisely why we still know the tale five centuries on. It is a perfect little window onto this court, a place credulous enough to fund alchemy for years, worldly enough to laugh when it crashed, and literary enough to write the joke down so well that we are still laughing.

The Baptism of 1566: A Party as Policy

The christening of the infant James, the future James the Sixth and First, in the Chapel Royal in December 1566 was the most lavish celebration Scotland had ever mounted, and it was not indulgence, it was statecraft in fancy dress. Mary, Queen of Scots staged three days of Renaissance spectacle, a Catholic baptism, courtly masques, a mock assault on a specially built fort, and a fireworks display believed to be the first ever recorded in Scotland. Every element was choreographed toward a single audience, the foreign ambassadors present, and a single message. This child is the future of the whole island of Britain.

The subtext was dynastic arithmetic that everyone in the chapel understood. Elizabeth the First of England, invited to stand as godmother, was unmarried and childless, and showed no sign of changing that. She did not attend, but she sent a magnificent gift, a heavy gold baptismal font, a diplomatic acknowledgment of exactly what was at stake. The baby being blessed at Stirling was the strongest claimant to Elizabeth's throne, and Mary was spending a fortune to make that claim look inevitable, royal, and Catholic, in front of the very people who would report home on it.

The darkness underneath the spectacle is what makes it unforgettable. The child's father, Lord Darnley, was in the castle but sulked in his chambers and refused to appear at his own son's baptism, his marriage to Mary already poisonous. Within ten weeks he would be dead, murdered in an explosion and strangulation at Kirk o' Field in Edinburgh, a scandal that would engulf Mary, drive her from her throne within the year, and deliver her eventually into Elizabeth's long captivity. Yet the cold logic of that Stirling christening was vindicated, posthumously and completely. Mary lost everything, but in 1603 her son did inherit England, uniting the crowns exactly as the 1566 pageant had implied he would. Every British monarch since descends from the baby baptized in that chapel. It was, in the end, the most successful party in British history, and its host did not live to see it pay off.

The Nursery of a Kingdom

There is a reason so many Scottish monarchs began life on this rock. Stirling was the Stewart dynasty's nursery and its panic room, the place where fragile royal children were raised precisely because the castle was the hardest in the kingdom to storm. And the dynasty produced fragile children with grim regularity. For generation after generation the crown passed to a minor, a baby or a boy, followed by the inevitable scramble of nobles to control the regency. All the Renaissance magnificence around you, the painted palace, the golden hall, the ceiling of emperors, was in part an anxious answer to that chronic weakness, a set of grand assertions that a dynasty forever ruled by infants was nonetheless permanent and divinely ordained.

Mary, Queen of Scots is the sharpest example. She became queen at six days old when her father James the Fifth died, reportedly heartbroken, days after her birth. She was crowned in the old chapel here in September 1543 at nine months, and spent her earliest years within these walls for one overriding reason, safety. Henry the Eighth wanted the infant queen betrothed to his son to swallow Scotland into England, and when persuasion failed he turned to war, the brutal campaign of raids and burnings the Scots bitterly nicknamed the Rough Wooing. Stirling's walls were the guarantee that the child at the center of it all could not simply be seized. In 1548, with the pressure mounting, she was moved on again and shipped to France for greater safety still.

One vivid tradition sharpens just how precarious it all was. The infant Mary is said to have survived a fire that broke out in her chamber here at Stirling, caught in time by an alert nursemaid. Whether or not every detail is reliable, pause on the counterfactual, because it is not idle. Had that fire, or any of a dozen childhood illnesses and accidents, taken the infant queen, there is no Mary, no son James, no union of the crowns in 1603, no shared monarchy of Britain. The entire subsequent shape of these islands rested, more than once, on the survival of a small child asleep in this castle. Stirling did not just guard a strategic bridge. For two centuries it guarded the thread of the succession itself.